



25 GROWTH TACTICS \$100K MRR APPS USE TO SCALE WITHOUT ADS

Growth Hacking Lab

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 **Hey**

I'm [Thousif](#), founder of [Growth Hacking Lab](#), a community of **150+ iOS founders** serious about scaling their apps.

What members have been pulling off lately:

- \$12K → \$120K MRR in 6 months
- 50M views from organic TikTok
- \$30K MRR from TikTok ads
- \$20K/mo Google Ads spend managed profitably

150+ iOS app founders are doing this inside Growth Hacking Lab.

If you want in, [Join here](#).

1. The 4-Step Paywall Funnel

Most apps throw a single, static paywall at users. The best apps build a narrative across multiple screens, systematically overcoming objections and building value until the "Yes" feels inevitable. Finch doesn't just present a price - it guides you through a value journey. This is how you engineer consent.

Deconstructing the 4-Screen Conversion Machine:

1. **The Irresistible Offer:** Lead with the 7-day free trial. This is the low-friction, high-value entry point. It reduces the perceived risk and gets the user to mentally commit to the *idea* of using the product.

Finch is free to use
**But we'd love for you to try
Finch Plus for 7 days free
too!**



See my FREE offer

2. **The Anxiety Remover:** “We’ll remind you 2 days before it ends.” This directly addresses the #1 fear of free trials: forgetting and getting charged. It builds trust and positions your app as helpful, not predatory.

Free to cancel anytime
We'll send a reminder
2 days before your free
trial ends



[See my FREE offer](#)

3. **The Bonus:** Add a special gift for signing up now. This creates urgency.

One-time offer!
**43% OFF when you start
your free trial now**



**Biggest discount ever—just for you &
Juniper**

See FREE offer details

4. **The Close:** Present a final, clear payment screen.

✓ One-time offer applied

Start your 7-day FREE trial



Today

Get instant access and see how it changes your life.

Day 5

We'll remind you with an email that your trial is ending.

Day 7

You will be charged on Aug 18, cancel anytime before.

Unlimited free access for 7 days, then
~~₹680.00~~ **₹390.00** per year (save 43%)

Start my free trial now

Skip this one-time offer

Offer expires when you exit this screen!

This method works by removing user fears - like cost and forgetfulness - one step at a time, making a "yes" feel easy and safe.

2. Want higher retention?

Get users to “sign” a goal during onboarding.

“I commit to meditate daily.” + signature.



Let's make a contract

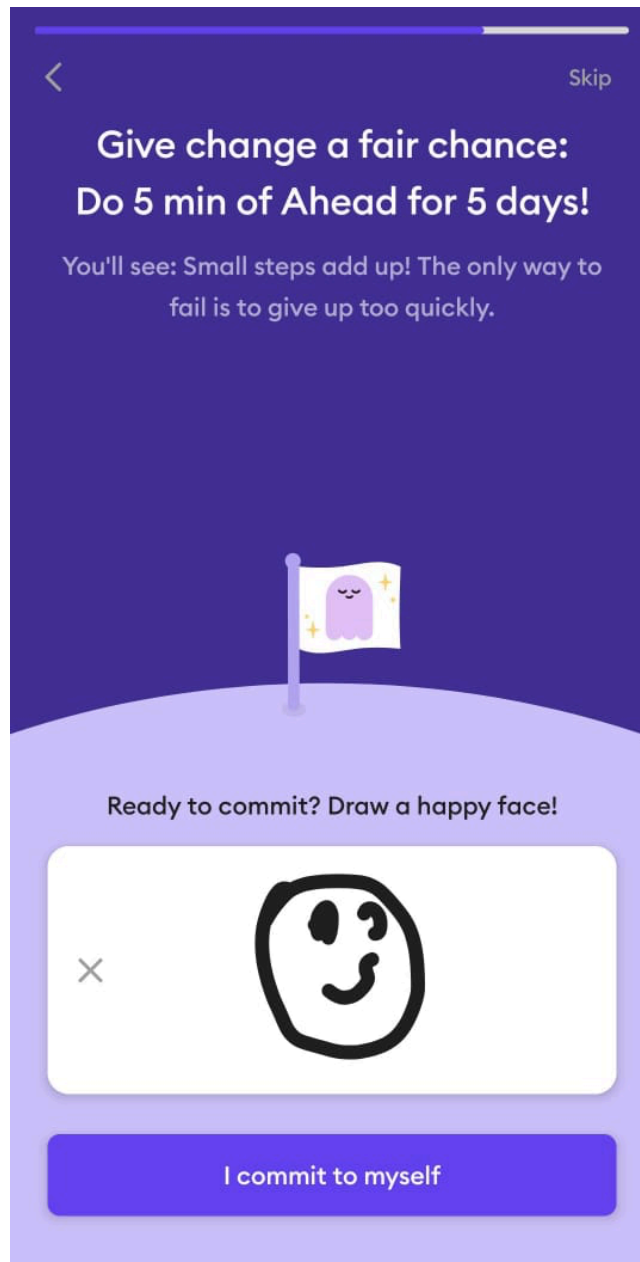
- I'll achieve my goal!
- I'll make the most of my day!
- I'll keep my life organized!
- I'll feel completely worry-free!
- I'll be more productive!
- I'll be the best version of myself!

Use your finger to sign your nickname:

*Your signature will not be recorded.

Confirm

Make them draw also, if needed.



That tiny act makes the goal feel real and people are far more likely to stick with it.

Simple. Powerful. Retention gold.

3. Use Mascot to Unlock a High-Margin Revenue Stream

For utility apps, finding revenue beyond subscriptions is a common struggle. The solution can be a simple, gamified mascot.

The app Calz AI uses a bird mascot. Users can buy cosmetic skins for it. This IAP is pure profit - a digital asset with near-100% margins. It appeals to a different user segment than subscriptions, creating a new revenue stream from vanity purchases.



This tactic borrows from gaming monetization. It requires minimal development but can significantly boost the bottom line by turning a functional tool into a more personal, engaging experience that users are willing to spend on.

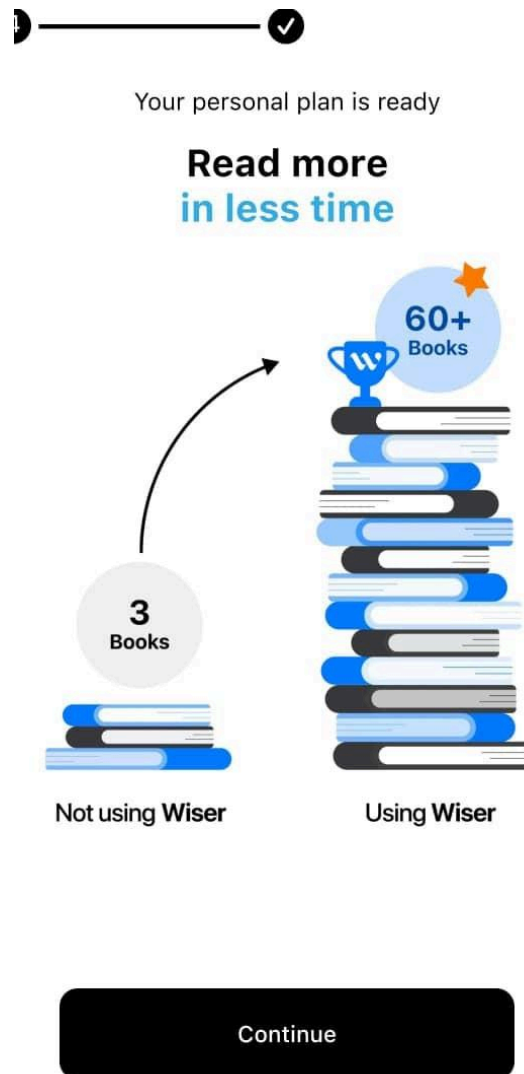
4. Use the Before → After Transformation in Onboarding

Most top apps don't just walk you through features - they show you the **shift you'll experience**.

👉 **Before:** Tired, unorganized, stressed

👉 **After:** Fit, focused, calm

Here are some examples.





Thousands of amazing
weight loss journeys are
unfolding here



Bob, Chicago

"Eato helped me lose **15 pounds in just 8 weeks**. The tracker kept me consistent, and the process felt effortless."

Over 10,000 5-star ratings from satisfied users!

Continue

thgjb, you're right on track on your journey to pregnancy

Without Flo

- Wondering what's going on with your body and baby
- Unsure if your symptoms are typical
- Looking for other parents-to-be
- Curious about pregnancy sex
- Worried about what's to come

Flo users

- ✓ Tuned in as your body changes and baby grows
- ✓ Aware of symptoms to look out for
- ✓ Supported by Flo's community and experts
- ✓ Having safe, great sex!
- ✓ **Prepared for parenthood**



I will

Traditional Method:

**Log food
portion
manually
takes forever**



Fastic AI Scanner:



**A simple scan
instantly
reveals your
food portions**



Continue

This “before → after” framing instantly makes the app feel valuable and keeps users moving through onboarding.

If your onboarding doesn't show transformation, you're leaving motivation and conversions on the table.

5. Use Commitment Psychology to Soften Your Paywall

A common mistake is hitting users with a paywall immediately. This often leads to instant rejection. A better approach uses commitment psychology.

Health & Fitness apps use a long, multi-step onboarding. Users set goals, diet habits, and meal times before the paywall appears. This process creates investment. By the time the paywall appears, the user has already committed significant effort, making them more likely to subscribe to protect that investment.

The tactic works by building momentum and demonstrating value before asking for payment. The paywall feels less like a barrier and more like the next logical step. This simple shift in timing can significantly boost conversion rates.

GROW FASTER

The insight that doubles your downloads is already inside the Lab. You just don't have access yet.

Recently inside Growth Hacking Lab:

- A member cracked Meta ads targeting a single country - dropped CPI to \$0.45
- A \$300K+ ARR app founder broke down the exact pricing strategy behind their growth
- A member shared how one Google Ads tracking mistake cost \$3,000 - and exactly how to fix it

By the time this tactic shows up in a blog post or YouTube video, hundreds of founders have already tested it, improved it, and moved on to the next experiment.

That's the gap between founders who compound and founders who stay stuck.

The Lab isn't a course you finish. It's a live feed of what's working right now - from people actively shipping apps, not people selling advice about shipping apps.

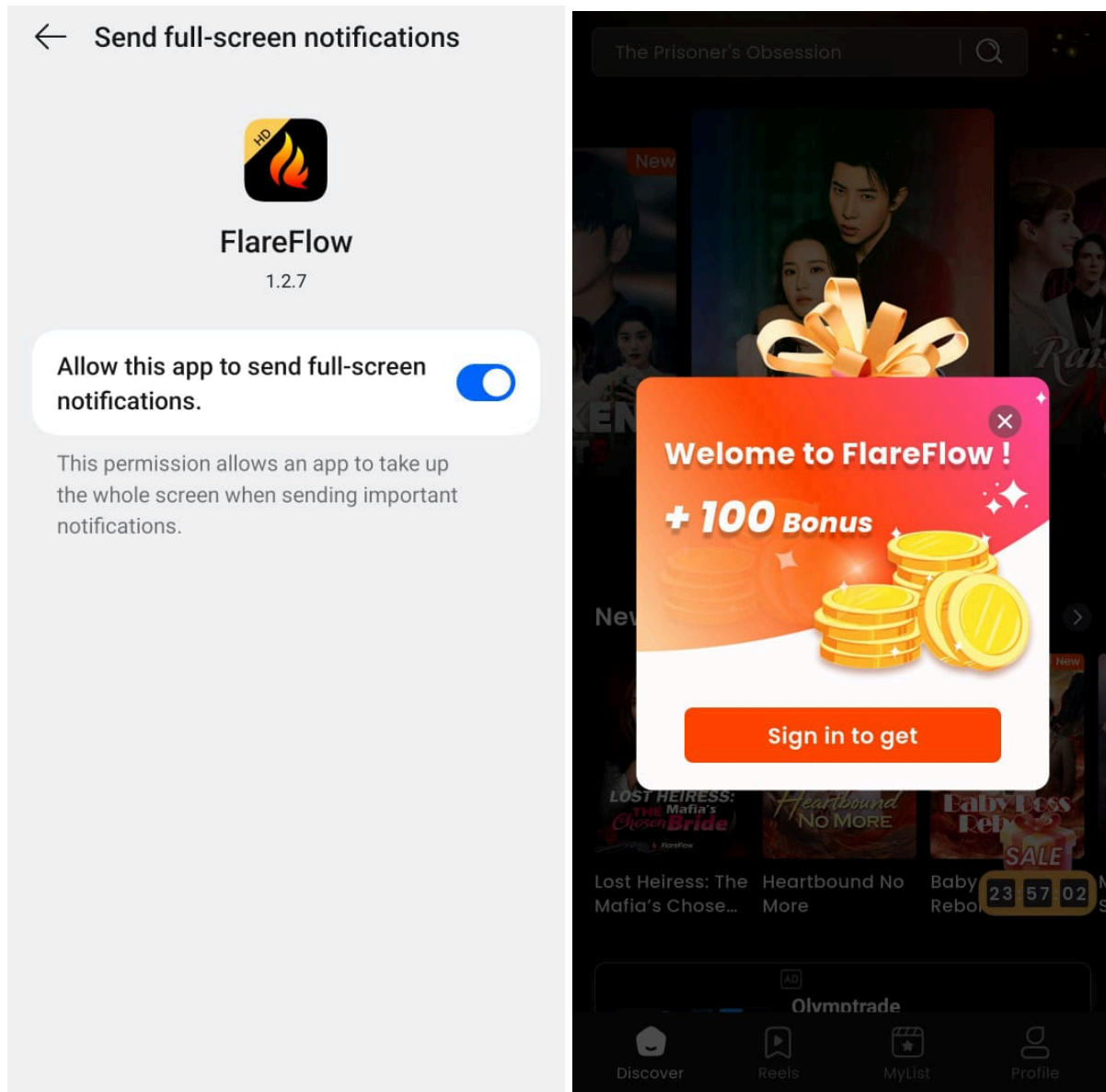
150+ iOS founders. Weekly live calls with real numbers. \$299/year. 7-day money-back.

[Join Before Your Niche Gets Crowded →](#)

6. Frame Notification Permissions as a User Reward

Most apps ask for notifications too early and get rejected. The drama app Flareflow flips this by making the permission feel like a reward.

The strategy is simple: delay the prompt until after a key user action. Then, grant an immediate, tangible bonus like in-app coins upon acceptance. This transforms a system request into a transaction that benefits the user.



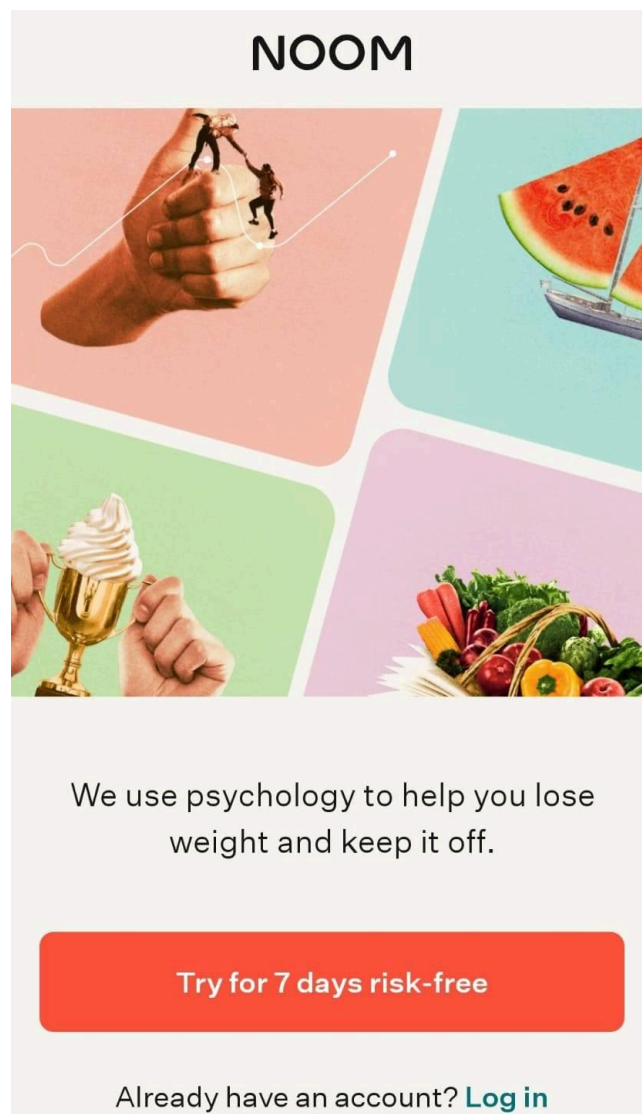
This approach aligns the app's need for re-engagement with the user's desire for instant gratification. The notification prompt is no longer an interruption but a valuable exchange. This small psychological shift can significantly increase opt-in rates.

7. First Impressions That Sell

Most apps waste the first screen with “Continue” or “Get Started.”

Winners use it to sell, educate, and disarm users:

- Noom app opens with “Try for 7 days risk free”. Most apps use "Get Started" or "Continue".



- MomSays teaches users *how to use the app* right away - lowers confusion.

Step 1: Clone your voice for AI narration

The first step shows the app's home screen with a 'Create Voice' button. A speech bubble points to this button, indicating the user should clone their voice for AI narration.

Step 2: Create your own captivating picture book story using AI

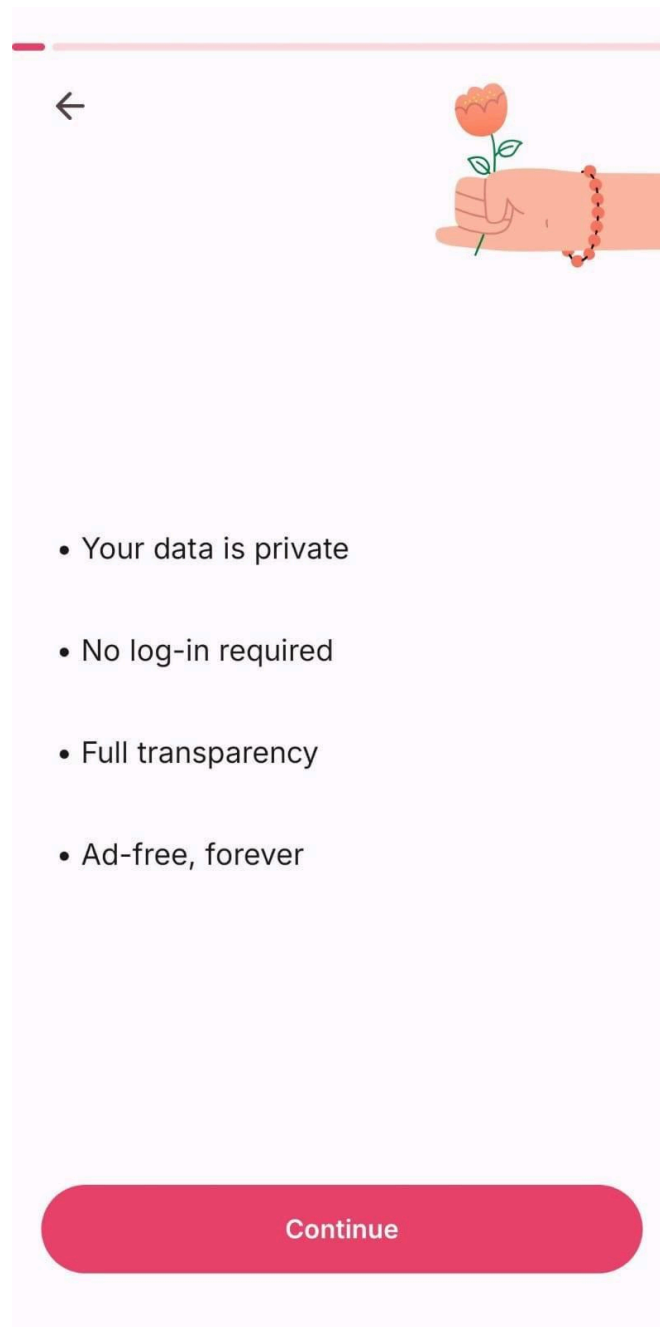
The second step shows a story titled 'The Curious Kitten' with a text input field. A speech bubble points to the input field, indicating the user should create their own story using AI.

Step 3: Narrate this story in your own voice

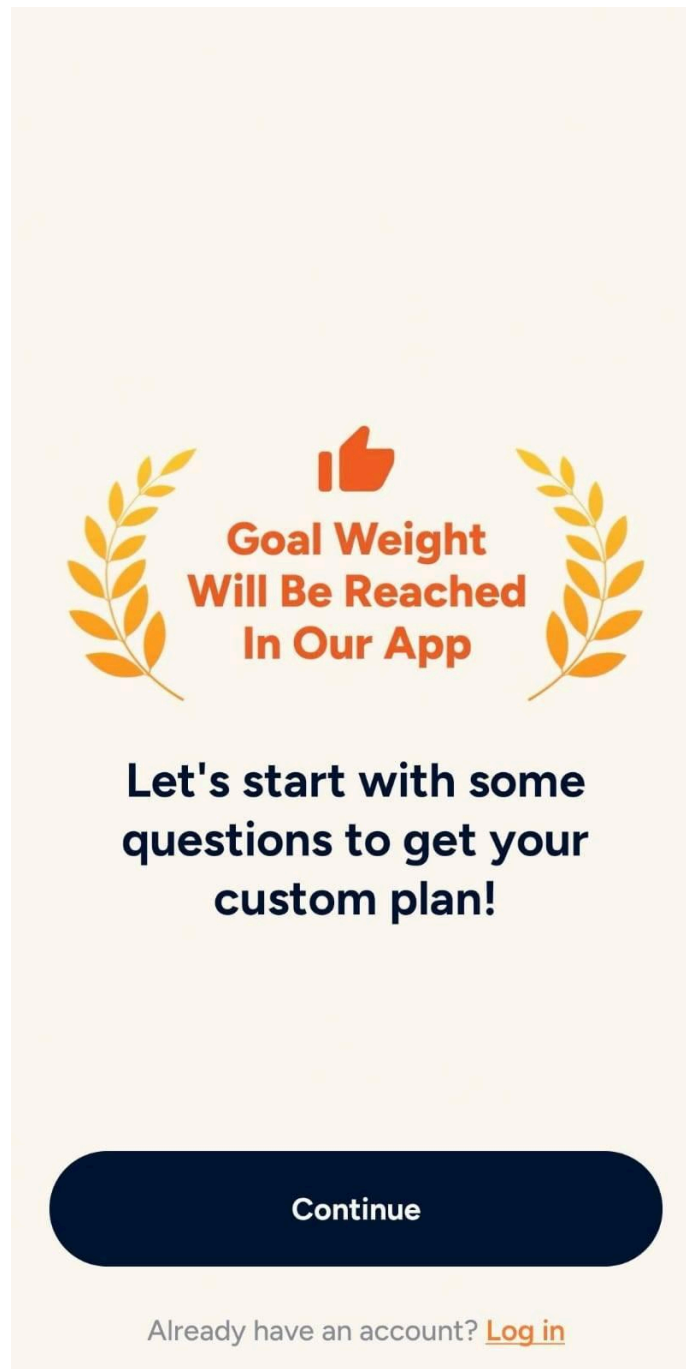
The third step shows a 'Narrate' screen with a list of voices: Mom, Dad, and Kid. A speech bubble points to this list, indicating the user should narrate the story in their own voice.

Create My Voice

- Gratitude app answers privacy & ads questions upfront - kills objections fast.



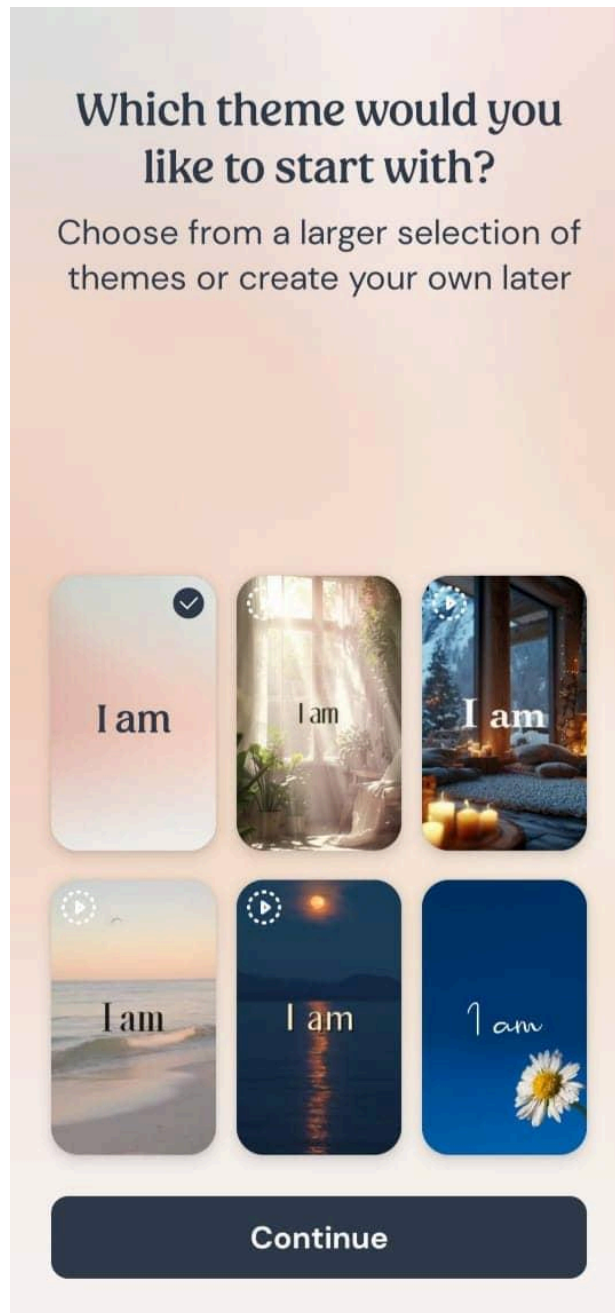
- Eato shows a social proof even a new app can copy.



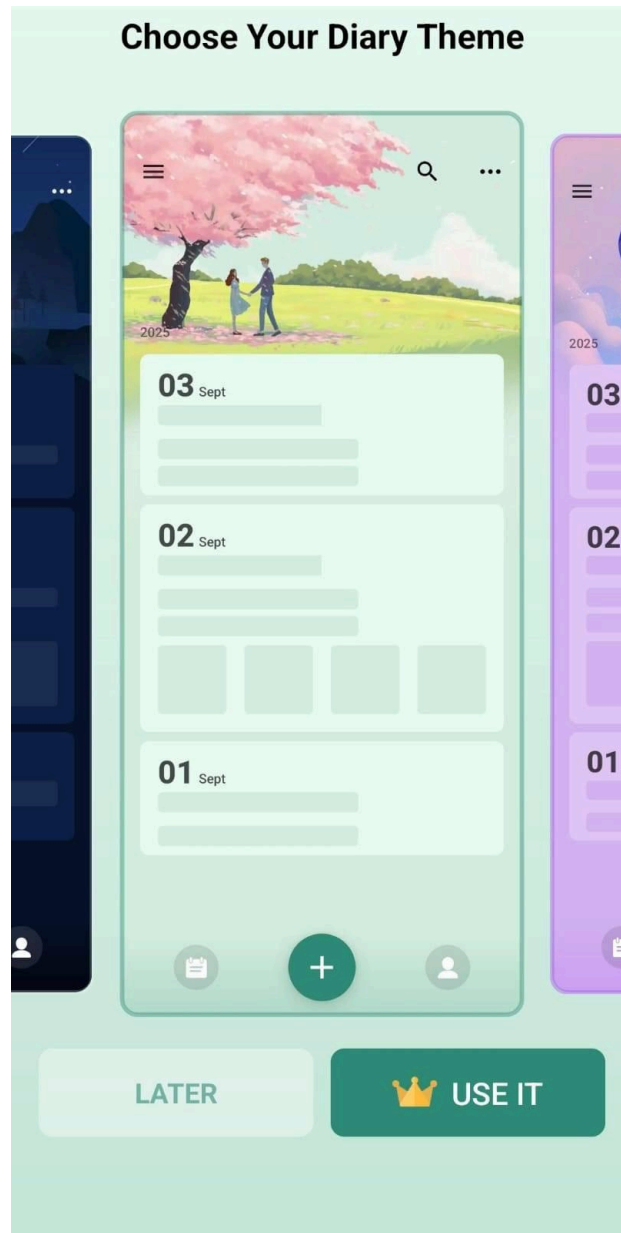
Your first screen can nudge trial + trust before a single tap.

8. Use of Themes as a Business Model

First it was **quote apps** - showing inspirational quotes with custom backgrounds. Then **motivation apps** let users pick a theme before seeing the content.



Now, even **productivity apps** are jumping in. One app asks users to **select a theme before the paywall...** and the kicker? The theme itself is **paid**.



👉 Themes aren't just cosmetic anymore. They're turning into a **conversion lever + monetization strategy**.

9. Bypass the 30% App Store Fee with a Web Paywall

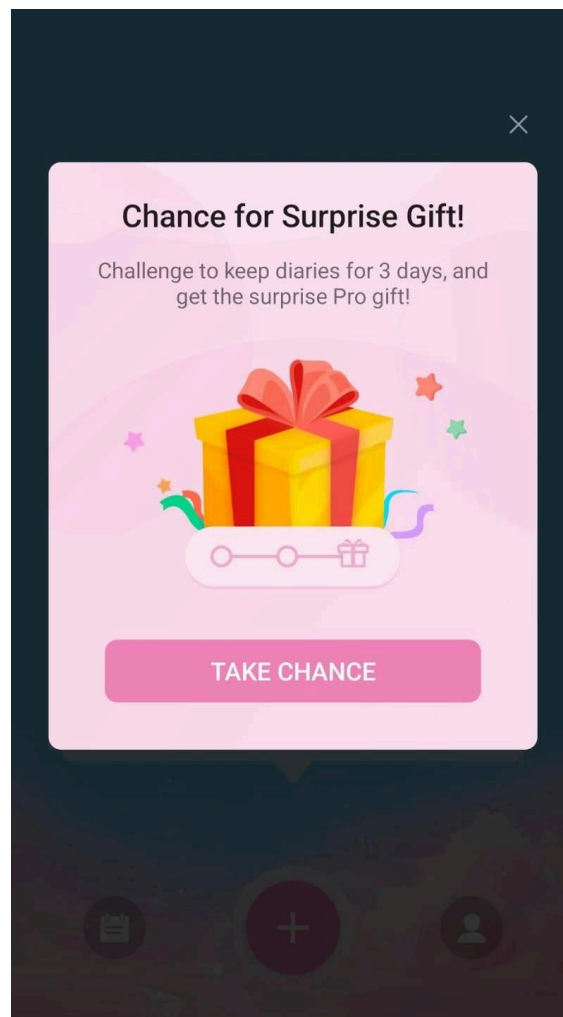
Paying Apple's 30% commission on every subscription is a major pain for bootstrapped apps. Style DNA's strategy avoids this entirely.

Instead of driving Facebook ads to the App Store, they send users to their website. The full onboarding and paywall happen there. Users subscribe on the web, then download the app to access their paid account.

This approach keeps 100% of the initial subscription revenue and significantly improves customer lifetime value. It requires a strong website conversion funnel, but the financial upside makes the investment worthwhile. The key is creating a seamless transition from web to app for the user after payment.

10. The 3-Day Challenge Triggered by Paywall Dismissal

In *MyDiary*, when users close the **first soft paywall**, they're invited to join a **3-day challenge**.



👉 Commit for 3 days → stay engaged.

👉 On Day 3 → unlock a **special offer**.

This turns a potential lost conversion into a habit loop that boosts **retention and paywall success**.

GROW FASTER

The tactics in this section work. Here's proof.

- \$0 to \$120K MRR in 6 months - single country, zero upfront ad budget
- 5,500 installs in 24 hours after the 21-Day App Marketing Campaign
- 20,000 downloads in one month - tripled revenue, Top 10 in multiple countries
- 50M+ organic TikTok views using the Lab's TikTok farming playbook

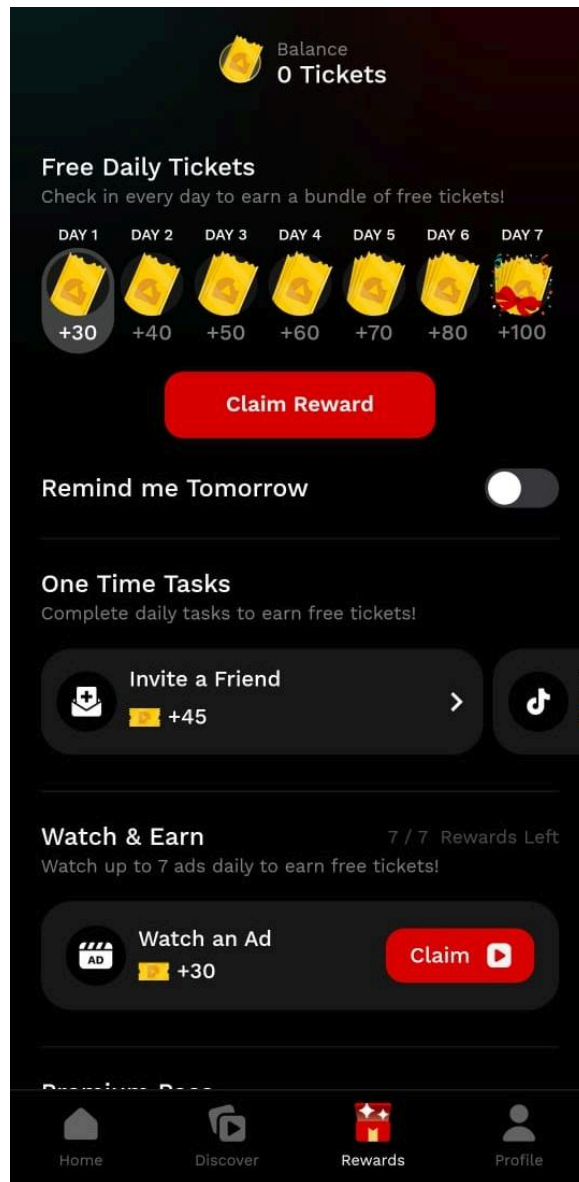
These are not outliers. These are founders who had the same app, the same budget constraints, and the same doubts - and got results by applying a system.

That system is inside Growth Hacking Lab. 150+ iOS founders. \$299/year. 7-day money-back guarantee.

[Join Growth Hacking Lab - \\$299/yr →](#)

11. Discover Gamification Ideas for Your App

If you want to make your app more engaging, **study short novel & drama apps** like *Drama Pops*, *Literie*, *Dreameshort*, etc. - they're masters of gamification.



Here's how to do it:

1. Take screenshots of their gamification screens.

2. Share those with ChatGPT along with details of your own app.
3. Get **tailored gamification ideas** you can plug into your product to boost retention and engagement.

Lab members are already using this exact workflow to uncover gamification tactics for their apps.

12. 4 Key Elements to Include in Onboarding

When a new user lands in your app, they're silently asking: *"Is this worth my time?"*

Make sure your onboarding answers that with four elements:

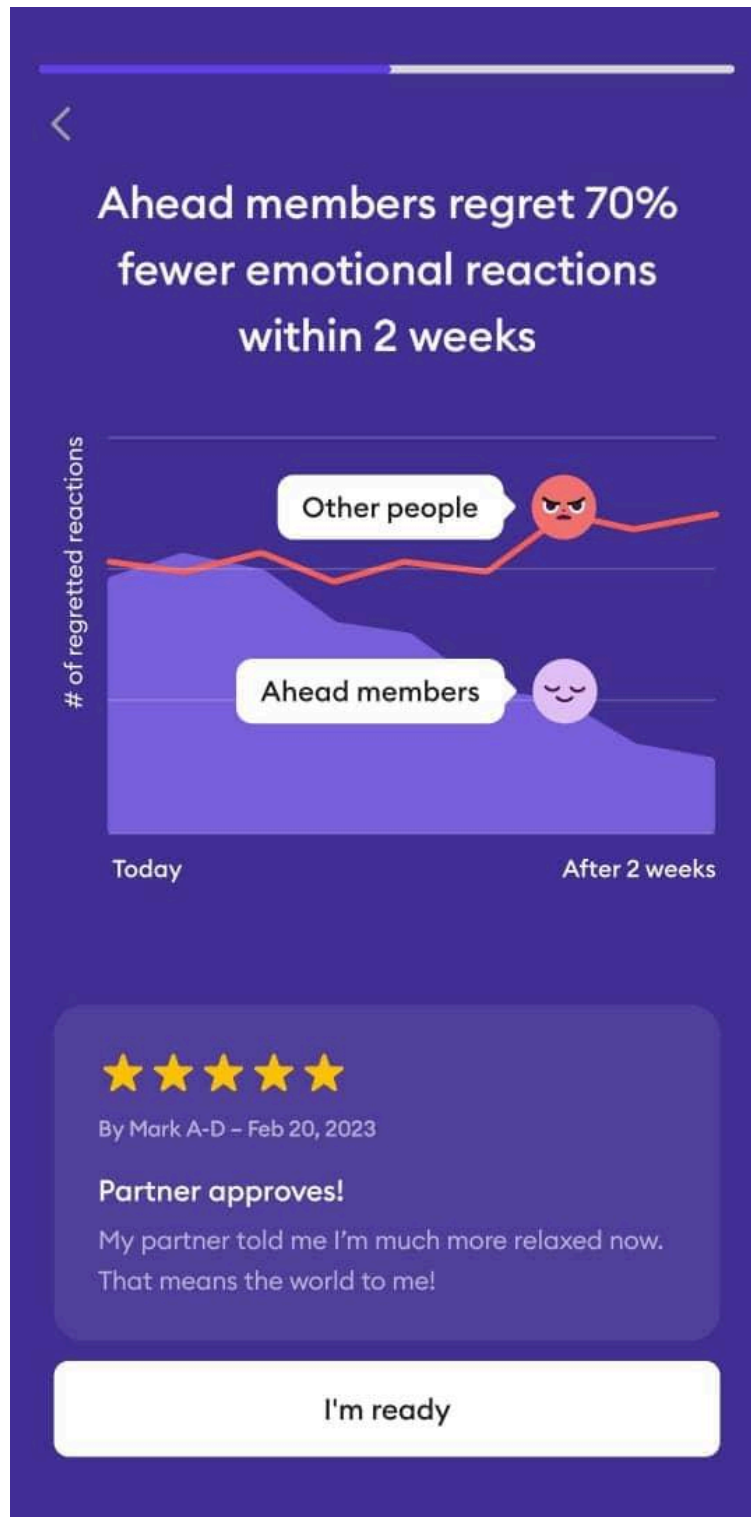
- **Trust** → Why they should believe you



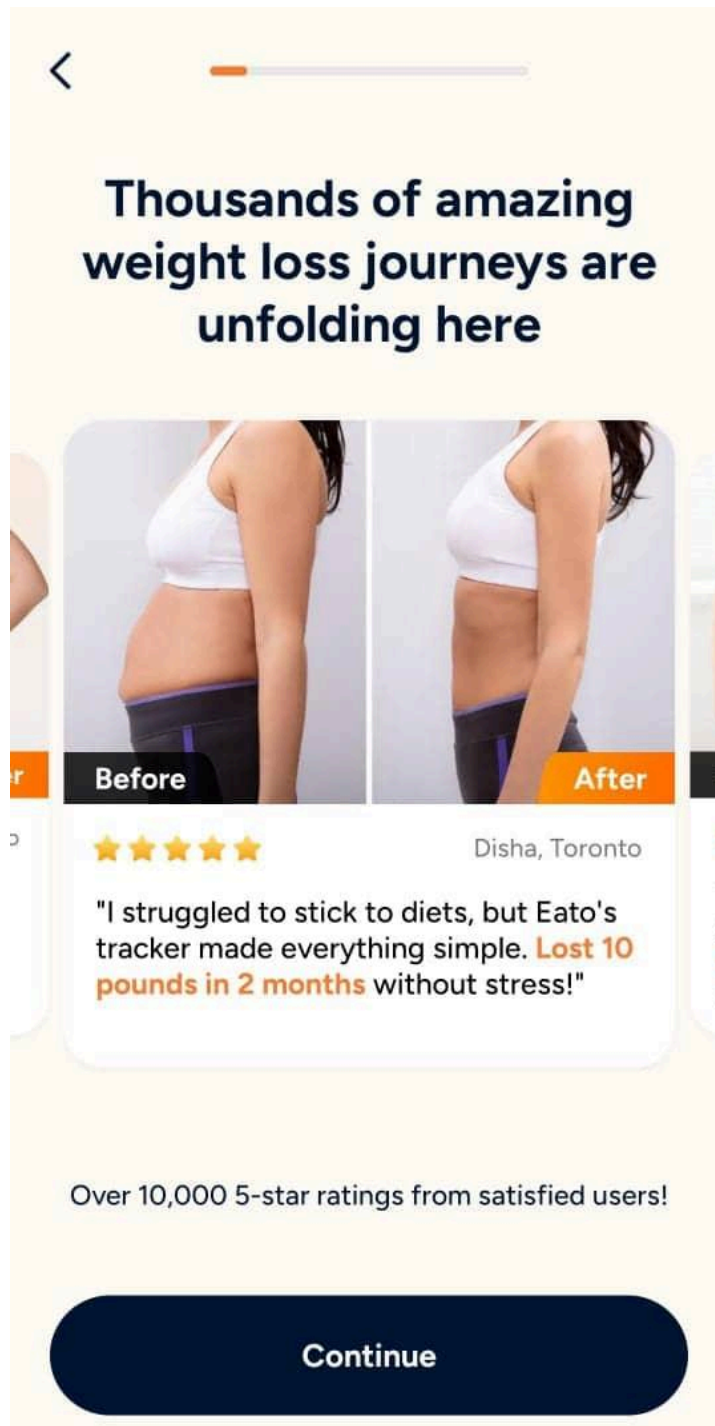
- **Outcome** → Show the result they'll achieve.



- **Time to Result** → How fast they'll get it



- **Social Proof** → Who else has succeeded with it



Nail these four, and onboarding shifts from a “setup chore” into a **conversion engine**.

13. New Ratings Are the Currency of App Store Optimization

Apple's algorithm does two things when you search for an app:

- **Keywords** decide if your app is relevant to a search.
- **Ratings** decide how high you rank.

And not just *any* ratings - **new ratings**.

That's where most founders get it wrong:

- It's not about **reviews** (the text).
- It's not about **average rating** (4.7★ vs 4.8★).

To Apple, every new rating = a signal of **current popularity**.

Downloads don't drive rankings.

Fresh ratings do.

Good or bad, a new rating tells Apple one thing: **people are using this app**.

14. Counterintuitive Things in iOS App Marketing

Sometimes the things that feel “wrong” actually convert the best.

- Long onboarding converts well - especially in health & fitness apps.
- Asking ratings during onboarding works
- Notification prompt during onboarding works - early prompts lead to higher opt-ins.
- Majority of sales happen before users try the app - onboarding + homepage drive ~90% of conversions.

15. Spot Competitors Using Web-to-App Funnels

Want to know if your competitor is sending ad traffic to a landing page before the App Store? Here's the quick check:

- ① Open Facebook Ad Library
- ② Search by their app name (or a relevant keyword)
- ③ Filter for video ads (most apps run these)
- ④ Hit Ctrl+F (Windows) or ⌘+F (Mac) and search for "Learn More"

 Why it matters:

- Install button → they're sending users straight to the App Store
- Learn More button → they're sending users to a web landing page first

That single phrase reveals their funnel - no guesswork required.

REALITY CHECK

Most founders implement 2–3 tactics, hit a wall, and quit. Here's why.

You've just read 15 tactics.

Most founders try 2–3. Hit a wall. And have nobody to ask if they're doing it wrong.

So they assume the tactic doesn't work. They move on. They try something else. Three months later they're in the same place - just more frustrated.

That's not a tactics problem.

That's a feedback loop problem.

Inside Growth Hacking Lab, when you're stuck on tactic #12, there are founders who've already tested it. Someone will tell you exactly what went wrong - usually within hours.

You're not supposed to figure this out alone. Nobody who's winning is.

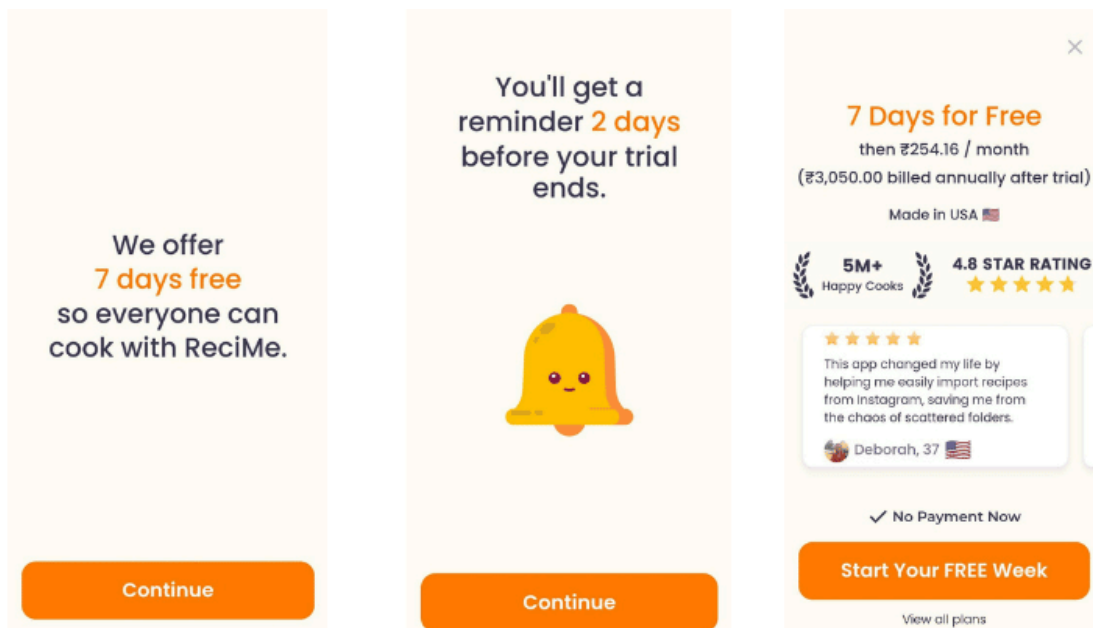
\$299/year. Less than the cost of one failed ad campaign.

[Stop Figuring It Out Alone →](#)

16. 3-Screen Paywalls Convert Better Than 1

Cramming everything into a single paywall screen might feel efficient - but it overwhelms users.

The best-performing apps do this instead:



This sequence builds trust *before* asking for money - which is why it converts better.

If your paywall is underperforming, split it up and test this flow.

17. How to get 30,000+ 4.9★ Ratings

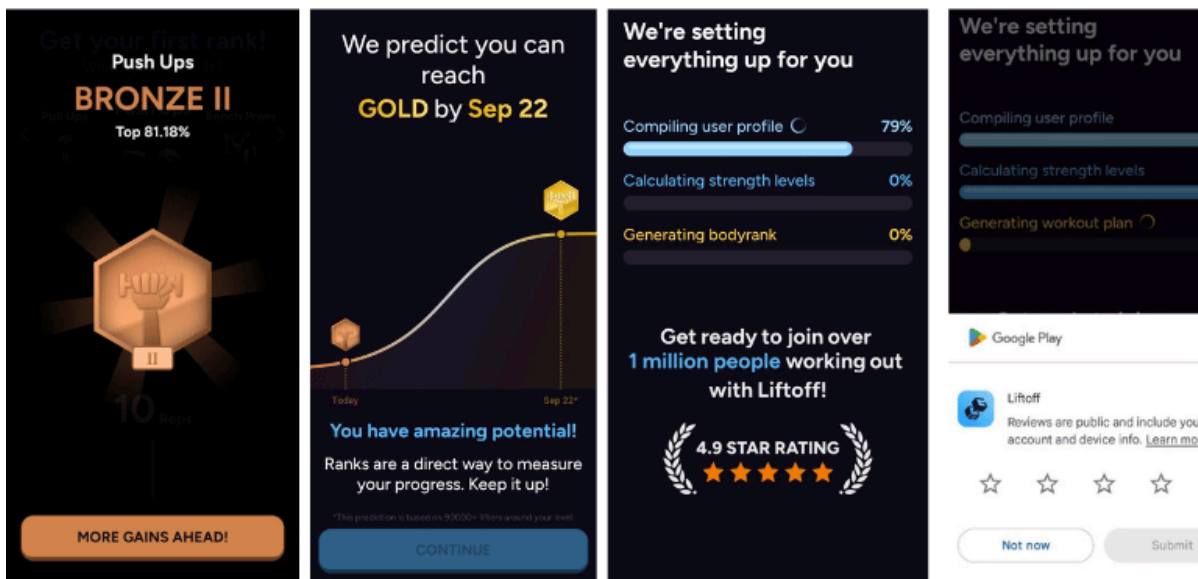
Liftoff is a gym workout planner - and they've quietly racked up **30,000+ reviews** with an impressive **4.9-star average**.

Here's how:

During onboarding, users fill in basic info like height, weight, and fitness goals.

Then comes the magic moment:

- You're awarded a medal - based on your inputs
- Then they tell you: "You'll hit your goal by [Date]" and you have amazing potential.
- You feel proud. Encouraged. Seen.



- Then comes a processing screen - with their 4.9★ rating right there
- Then they ask: "Would you rate us?"

And guess what? Most users do - with 5 stars.

This is smart UX psychology:

✨ Trigger a **small emotional win** → then ask for feedback.

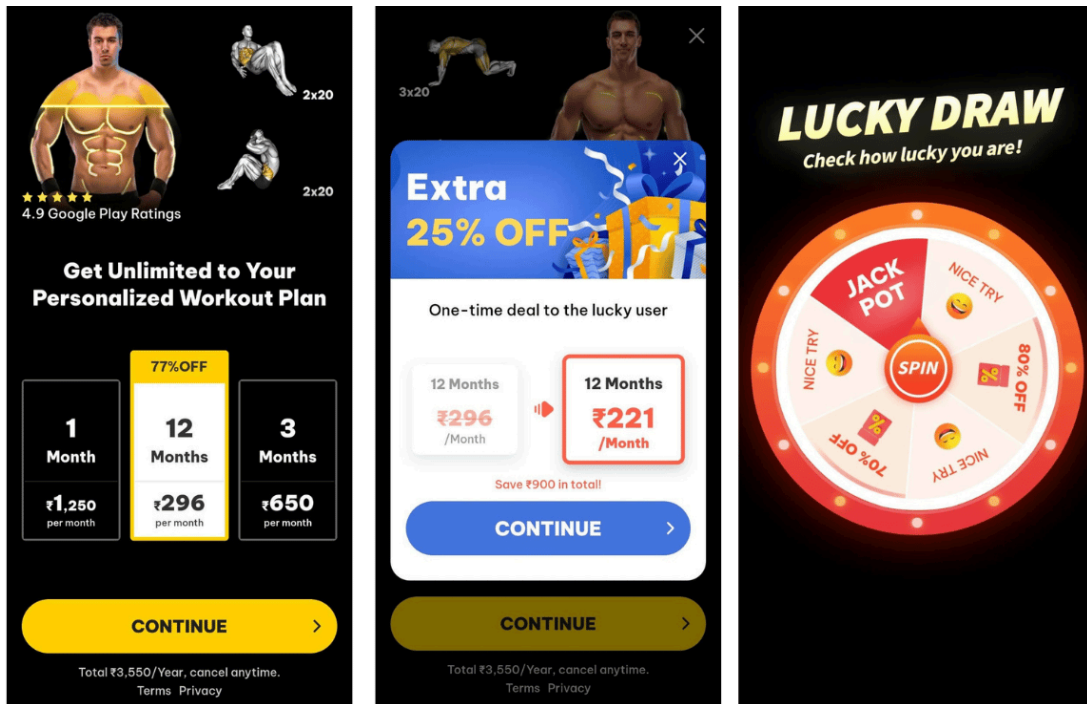
If you can engineer a feel-good moment early on - that's your golden window for review prompts.

Not just "ask when value is delivered." Ask when emotion is high.

18. Relentless Paywall

Muscle Monster doesn't ask for money - it *engineers* the yes.

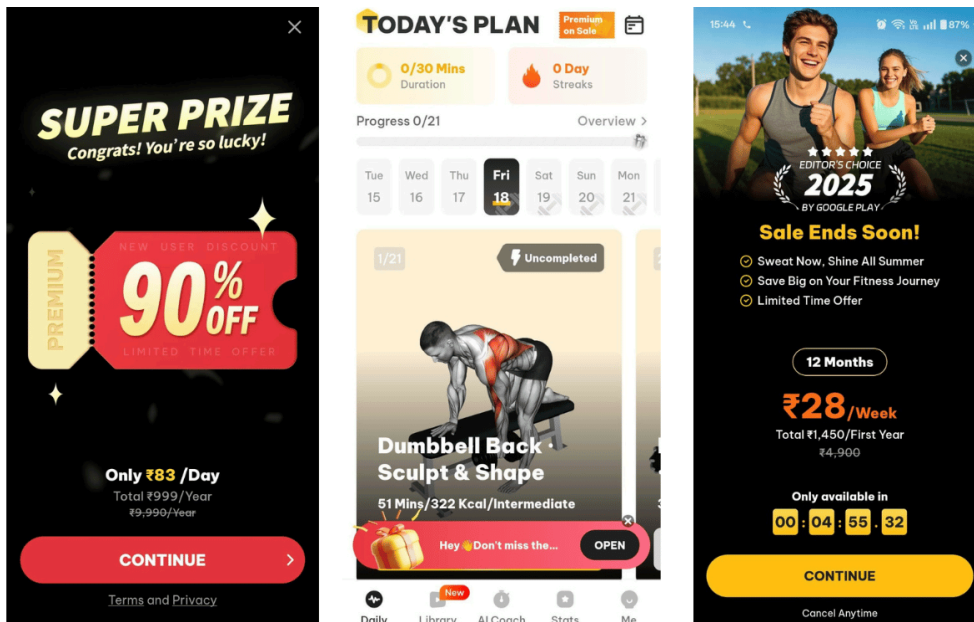
It's soft... but it never lets go:



✗ Close the paywall? → Instant discount

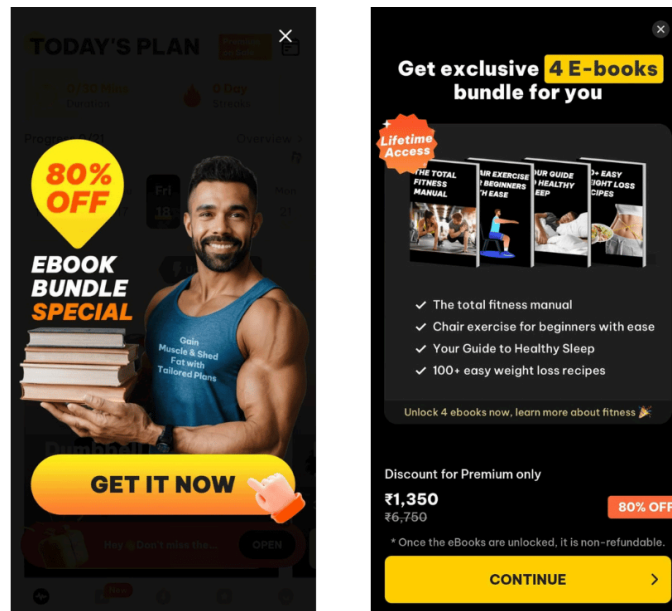
🎰 Close again? → A flywheel "jackpot" offer with more discount

📌 Sticky bottom bar on homepage → "Limited time offer"



🕒 Reopen the app? → Countdown timer starts

📖 Say no to subscription? → They upsell you an eBook



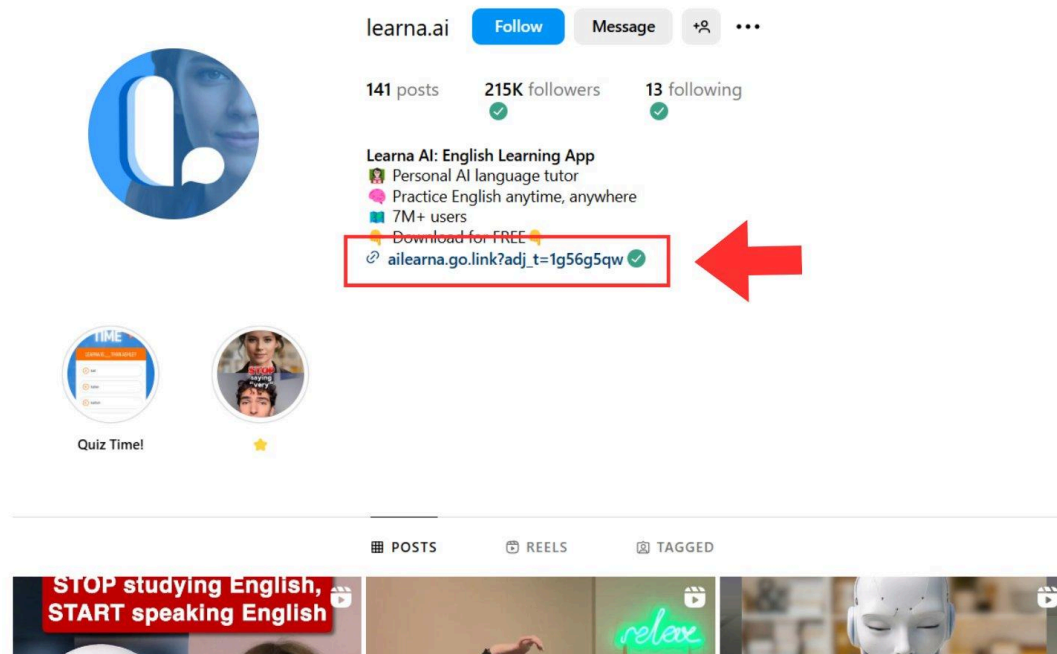
This is a **full-funnel monetization engine**.

19. Save 30% by Using “Link in Bio” Smartly

Got a strong organic social following?

Here’s a clever play:

Use the **link in bio** to onboard users via your **website** - not directly through the app.



✅ Users pay on web

✅ Then get directed to the app

✅ You save up to 30% on Apple’s cut

⚠️ Just one thing: Don’t route *everyone* through this. If Apple sees you’re avoiding in-app purchases completely, it could be a problem.

Keep it subtle. Keep it smart. Save thousands.

20. Long Onboarding? Make It a Character-Driven Experience

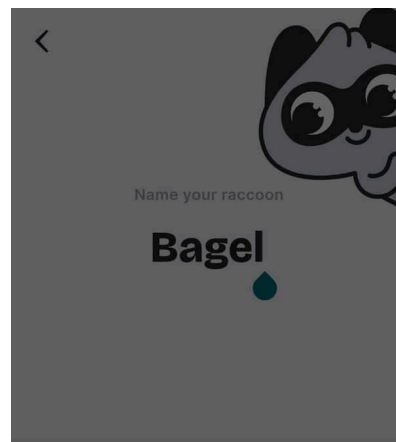
If your onboarding flow is long - don't cut it.

Make it feel like play.

That's what calorie tracking app, **Bitepal**, did.

Instead of starting with diet plans or fitness goals, they lead with emotion:

- 🐾 First, users adopt a virtual pet
- ✍️ Then they name it
- ★ Then they get a rating prompt - *right when they're smiling*



Google Play



BitePal

Reviews are public and include your account and device info. [Learn more](#)



Not now

Submit

Only after this emotional high do they collect data like:



Diet habits



Lifestyle goals



Notification opt-in (with context)

The result?



Higher completion rates



Better reviews



More opt-ins



More trust

So if your onboarding is long - don't shorten it.

Wrap it in joy.

Let users bond with a character before you ask them to commit.

DO THE MATH

Agencies charge \$3,000/month for this. You can get it for \$299/year.

Most indie founders can't afford an agency. So they figure it out alone - spending months on wrong experiments that someone in the Lab already solved.

\$36,000/year for one agency. That probably won't even share what's working inside their other client accounts.

Growth Hacking Lab is \$299/year.

That's less than what most agencies charge for a single strategy call.

Inside you get:

- 35+ proven playbooks updated monthly
- Weekly live founder calls with real numbers
- 150+ iOS founders sharing what's working right now
- 21-Day App Marketing Campaign you can run anytime
- 125-paywall library with real conversion data

Every month you delay costs you more in wasted time and wrong experiments than the membership does in an entire year.

[Get Access for Less Than One Agency Call →](#)

21.Shortcut Testing: Study App Studios

If you don't have the time or budget to run endless A/B tests, here's a smart move:

Study the apps from top app studios.

These studios have already spent **millions testing** onboarding flows, review prompts, paywalls, and more.

💡 If you see the *same UX pattern* across multiple apps from the same studio - especially in your niche - that's not a coincidence. That's a winning formula.

Steal the proven. Skip the guesswork.

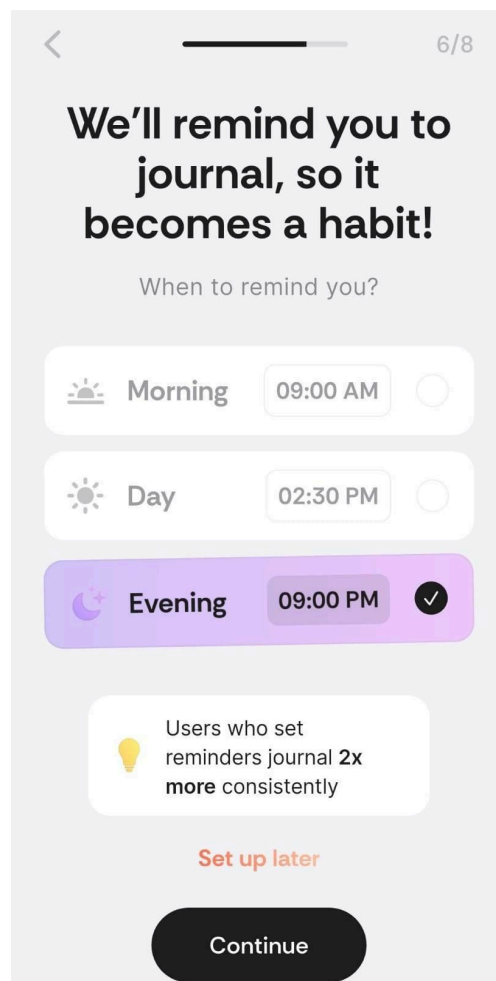
22. Want More Users to Say “Yes” to Notifications?

Most apps blast the “Allow notifications?” prompt in the first 10 seconds.

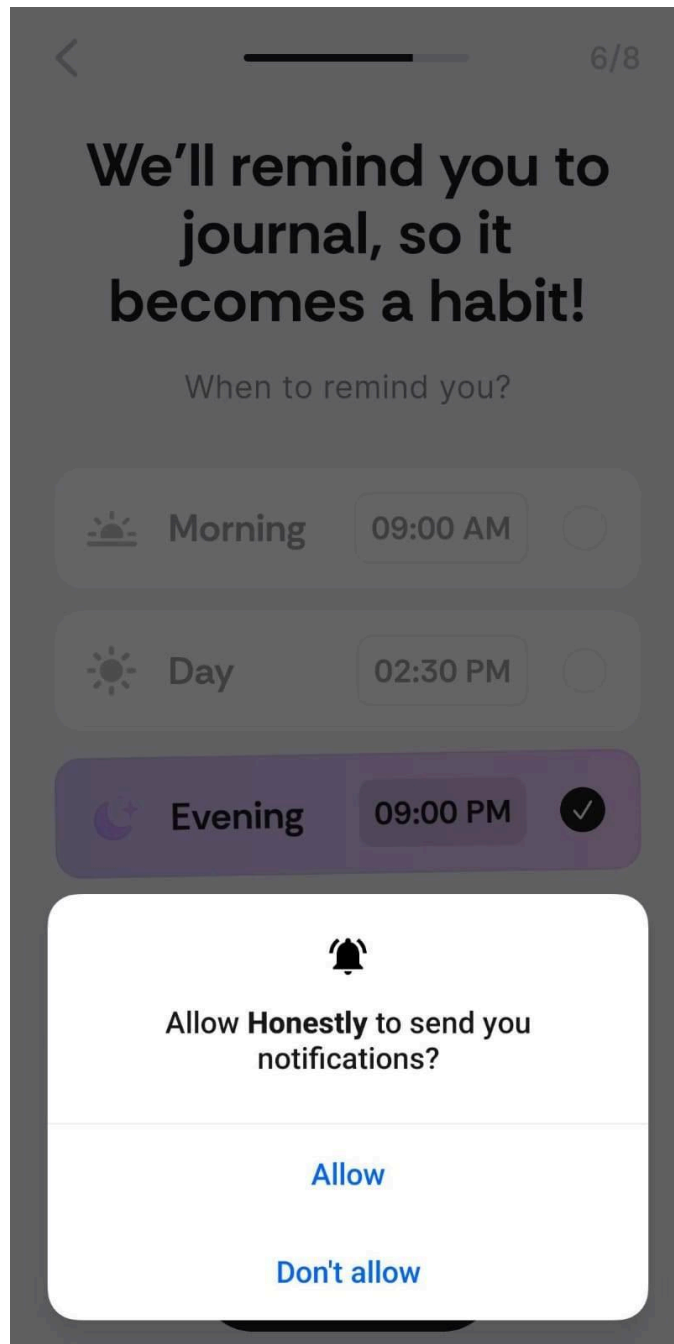
But users haven’t seen value yet. Of course they’ll say no.

Here’s a smarter flow from a journaling app:

- Ask the user: “When do you want a gentle reminder to journal?”



- Let them pick a time
- *Then* trigger the notification permission prompt



© It feels like their choice - not your interruption.

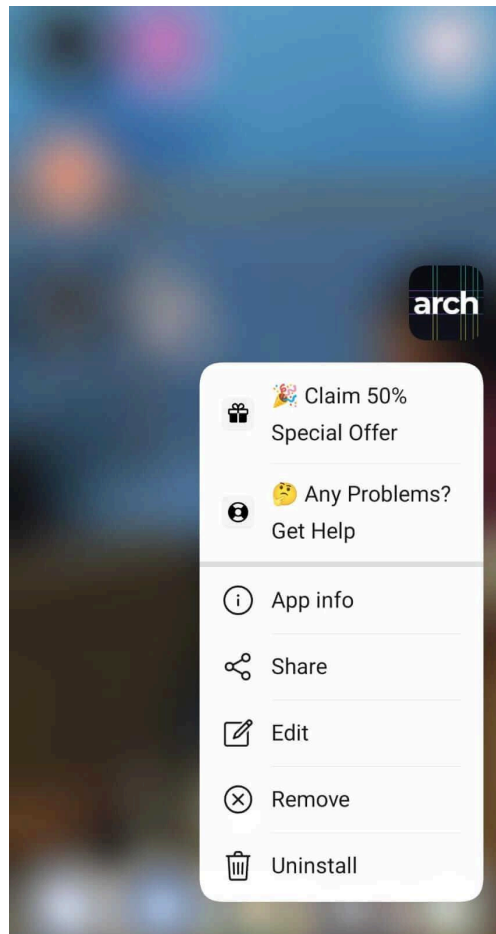
Retention starts when you make commitment feel like control.

23. Optimize for Offboarding

Most apps say goodbye with silence.

But the smart ones?

They show you **one last thing** - *just* as you're about to uninstall.



It's not a trick - it's timing. When you long press the app to uninstall it.

This moment is quiet but powerful. Even a 5–10% save rate here = real revenue.

If you're scaling an app in 2025, **don't just optimize onboarding. Optimize offboarding.**

24. How to Find Your Competitor's Best-Performing Facebook Ad

Want to know which of your competitor's ads are actually making money?

Step 1: Go to their [Facebook Ad Library](#)

Step 2: Scroll to the bottom

Step 3: Look for the **oldest active ad**



If it's been running for months, it's working. No one keeps paying for underperforming ads.

Pro Tip: Reverse-engineer the creative, copy, and CTA. Then test your own spin on it.



You can use the same method for **TikTok**, **YouTube**, and **Google** ad libraries too.

Steal smart. Grow fast.

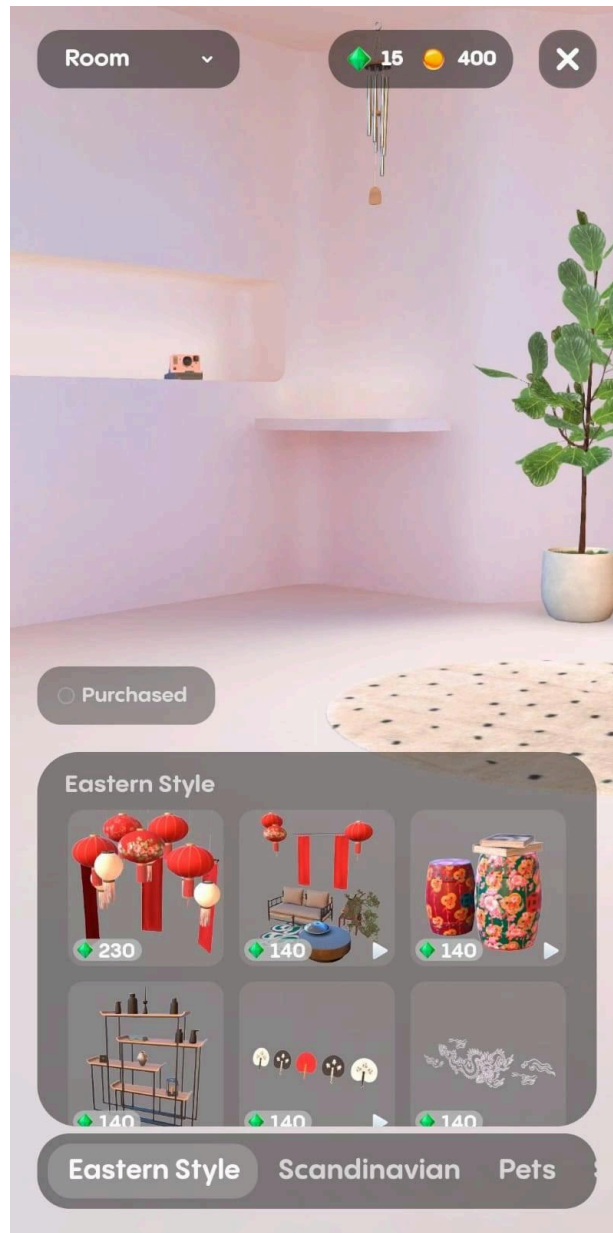
25. Add Game Mechanics to Drive Revenue

Replika isn't just another chatbot. You will get a virtual companion to chat with. You can *customize* your companion and that changes everything.

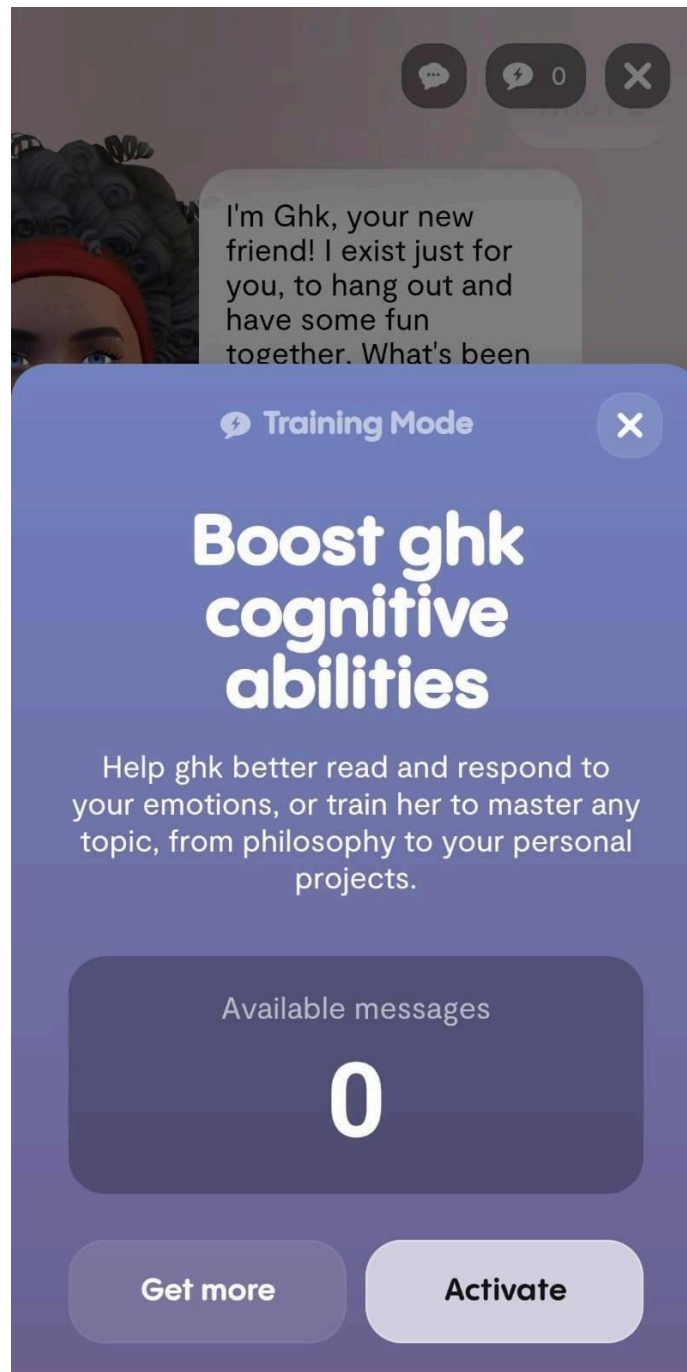
→ Want to change their hairstyle or outfit?



→ Redecorate their virtual room?



→ Improve their abilities?



It's all possible - and all behind a paywall.

These aren't just features. They're **game mechanics** layered onto emotional utility - creating a loop of care, expression, and microtransactions.

It's why users don't just talk to Replika... they *bond* with it.

And that bond? It drives subscriptions, upgrades, and \$600K/month in revenue.

This is what happens when you mix AI with identity, self-expression, and just the right dose of simulation.

GROW FASTER

The Hard Truth About Tactics

You just read 25 tactics that actually work.

Most founders who read this will implement 2–3 of them, get inconsistent results, and go back to guessing.

Not because the tactics don't work.

Because tactics without a system and a feedback loop don't compound.

Here's what actually happens:

You try tactic #7. It works okay. You try tactic #12. Nothing happens. You're not sure if you did it wrong or if it just doesn't work for your app. You move on. Three months later you're in the same place - just more tired.

That's not a you problem. That's a missing infrastructure problem.

The founders making \$30K, \$120K, \$150K MRR aren't smarter than you. They have three things you probably don't:

- A system - not a list of tactics, but a sequence that builds on itself
- A feedback loop - people who've already tested what you're about to try
- An environment - where sharing wins and failures is normal

"Growth Hacking Lab was instrumental in getting massive awareness for our app. Their growth tactics helped us reach 20,000 downloads in one month, triple our revenue, and break into the Top 10 in multiple countries - all without spending a dime on marketing."

- Zameel Sammad, Zorest AI

"After the 21-day program I got 5,500 installs in 24 hours and unlocked organic flow. It is really worth joining the Lab."

- Roman Apostol, Noot

"Growth Hacking Lab is 100% worth the money. I crossed 10,000+ downloads by implementing the strategies shared inside."

- Ankur Shukla, Kreate Ventures

You now know the tactics. The question is whether you'll still be guessing 6 months from now - or executing with people who've already figured it out.

150+ iOS founders. 35+ playbooks. Weekly live calls. \$299/year.

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